

Rainforests and Lakes



THE TROPICAL RAINFORESTS of Africa stretch in a broad band from West Africa to the edge of the Great Rift Valley. This valley is a huge trough more than 4,000 miles (6,440 km) long. The valley floor has many lakes, which provide a rich habitat for wildlife.

The warm, humid environment of the rainforest is home to many animals, from okapis and forest birds to frogs, snakes, and insects. Many of the plant-eating animals feed on the leaves of shrubs beneath the giant forest trees. Leaves and fruits that fall to the forest floor decay rapidly, providing food for pigs, porcupines, and termites. Camouflage helps many animals hide from enemies and creep up on their prey without being seen. Unfortunately, large areas of rainforest have been destroyed for farming or building on, and many of the animals face possible extinction.

Armor plating

The pangolin is protected by hornlike scales, which act as a suit of armor. It uses its long tail as an extra hand, and can even hang from branches by the tip of its tail. The pangolin feeds on ants and termites, using its strong front legs to tear open their nests.



Common African pangolin
(*Manis tricuspis*)
Body length: up to 17 in (43 cm)
Tail: up to 2 ft (62 cm)

Royal antelope (*Neotragus pygmaeus*)
Body length: up to 1 ft 8 in (51 cm)
Height at shoulder: up to 10 in (26 cm)



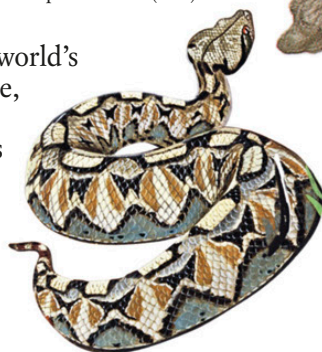
Gentle giant

Gorillas are gentle vegetarians, and feed on leaves, stalks, bark, and fruits. They live in close-knit groups of up to 30 members, each led by an adult male. Gorillas communicate with one another using a wide range of sounds and gestures. Male gorillas over 10 years old have silvery-grey hair on their backs and are nicknamed "silverbacks."



Western gorilla
(*Gorilla gorilla*)
Body length: up to 3 ft 6 in (1 m)

Gaboon viper
(*Bitis gabonica*) Length: up to 6 ft 9 in (2 m)



Pencil legs

The tiny royal antelope is the size of a rabbit and its legs are as thin as pencils. It is the world's smallest antelope. When escaping from enemies, such as larger mammals, birds, and snakes, the royal antelope can leap as far as 9 ft (2.7 m) in one bound. It hides in the day and feeds at night.

Fearsome fangs

The gaboon viper is the world's heaviest venomous snake, with enough venom to kill 20 people. It also has the longest fangs—up to 2 in (5 cm) long—enabling it to inject venom deep into the bodies of its prey.

Okapi
(*Okapia johnstoni*)
Length: up to 6 ft 10 in (2.1 m)
Height at shoulder: 5 ft 7 in (1.7 m)



Stripey legs

The stripes on the okapi's legs help to hide it from enemies, such as the leopard, when it stands among the trees. It feeds on leaves, which it pulls from trees and bushes with its long tongue. The okapi's closest relation is the giraffe, which explains the male okapi's short, fur-covered horns.

Powerful hunter

The leopard is so strong that it can drag the dead body of an animal weighing almost as much as itself. It stores large items of food in the branches of a tree to stop other animals from stealing its meals. The leopard's prey includes antelopes, monkeys, birds, fish, and snakes.



Leopard
(*Panthera pardus*)
Body length: up to 6 ft 3 in (1.9 m)
Tail: up to 3 ft 3 in (1 m)